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ICE NEWSROOM

MARCH 6, 2026 • NATCHEZ, MS • DETAINEE DEATH NOTIFICATIONS

Criminal illegal alien in ICE custody passes away in Natchez, Mississippi

NATCHEZ, Miss. — Pejman Karshenas Najafabadi, a 59-year-old criminal illegal alien from Iran, who was **convicted of conspiracy to possess with intent to distribute cocaine, possession of fentanyl, theft, and had been previously arrested for several other crimes**, passed away in ICE custody. On March 1, 2026, at approximately 6:32 p.m., he was pronounced deceased at Merit Health Hospital in Natchez, Mississippi following cardiac arrest, despite lifesaving efforts of hospital staff. He had been receiving care from a hospital since February 20th.

Karshenas had a documented medical history including cardiac arrest, inflammation of the heart and methicillin-resistant staphylococcus aureus (MRSA).

Karshenas was originally admitted into the United States in 1991 as a Lawful Permanent Resident. However, he threw away his chance at the American dream and was arrested for a litany of crimes over the years, **including prostitution, aggravated assault with a deadly weapon, criminal impersonation, driving under the influence, leaving the scene of an accident, and reckless driving**.

On September 22, 2009, Karshenas was arrested by the Drug Enforcement Administration in Nashville, TN, and **charged with conspiracy to possess with intent to distribute cocaine**. He was convicted and sentenced for federal probation for one year.

On August 22, 2014, ICE arrested Karshenas in Nashville, TN and initiated removal proceedings as a result of his felony conviction per federal law enshrined by the Immigration and Nationality Act. While an Immigration Judge ordered Karshenas removed to Iran on October 23, 2014, ICE was unable to obtain travel documents to Iran at that time. Karshenas was released under an Order of Supervision.

On March 29, 2025, Karshenas was arrested for **reckless endangerment, possession of unlawful drug paraphernalia, driving under the influence, and simple drug possession-fentanyl**. He was convicted of **possession of fentanyl**. ICE lodged an immigration detainer and took custody of Karshenas on April 22, 2025.

Karshenas was initially detained at the Winn Correctional Center in Winnfield, Louisiana, pending his removal proceedings. ICE conducted a health evaluation of Karshenas on April 25, 2025, and discovered he had several chronic health conditions prior to being taken into ICE custody. He received prescriptions and vaccinations to address these issues, and received constant medical care throughout his detention at ICE.

He received a second medical intake screening upon his transfer to the Louisiana ICE Processing Center in Angola on October 25, 2025, which reported no significant or life-threatening medical issues.

During another health screening on February 20, 2026, on-site ICE Health Service Corps staff evaluated Karshenas again for his ongoing medical concerns and prolonged illness. He was subsequently transferred to Riverbridge Specialty Hospital (RSH) in Vidalia, Louisiana for long-term care.

Around 4pm Central Time on March 1, 2026, RSH medical staff reported that Karshenas was “stable without any sign of distress and he denies any pain.”

Karshenas experienced cardiac arrest around 6:00pm CT that same day. Medical staff initiated CPR and continued life-saving efforts during ambulance transport to Merit Health Hospital. Upon arrival, Merit Health Hospital medical professionals continued resuscitation efforts; Karshenas was pronounced deceased at 6:32 p.m.

ICE makes official notifications to Congress, nongovernmental organization stakeholders and the media upon official reports of in-custody alien deaths and posts news releases with relevant details on ICE's public website. You may access this information in [ICE.gov's Newsroom](#). Congressional requirements described in the DHS Appropriations Act of 2018

require ICE to publicize all reports regarding in-custody deaths within 90 days. You may access these reports on [ICE.gov's Detainee Death Reporting page](#).

ICE is committed to ensuring that all those in custody reside in safe, secure and humane environments. Comprehensive medical care is provided from the moment individuals arrive and throughout the entirety of their stay. All people in ICE custody receive medical, dental and mental health intake screenings within 12 hours of arriving at each detention facility; a full health assessment within 14 days of entering ICE custody or arrival at a facility; access to medical appointments; and 24-hour emergency care. At no time during detention is a detained alien denied emergency care.

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MEDIA INQUIRIES

For media inquiries about ICE activities, operations or policies, contact ICE's Office of Public Affairs at ICEMedia@ice.dhs.gov.

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